

The Exorcism of Emily Rose

Part I: The Body / The Case Opens (Ultra-Density)

THE EXORCISM OF EMILY ROSE

PROLOGUE: THE BARN

The cold in November didn't just sit on the skin; it burrowed. It found the gaps in your coat, the seams in your boots, the hollow spaces in your chest. It was a living thing, a predator that had been waiting for the sun to go down so it could feed.

Maria Rose stood on the back porch of the farmhouse, her hands wrapped around a ceramic mug that had gone lukewarm ten minutes ago. It was a novelty mug, something Emily had bought her at the state fair years ago. It said *World's Okayest Mom* in faded blue letters. Maria traced the letters with a thumb that was cracked and stained with garden soil. She wasn't drinking the coffee. She was just holding it, using the ceramic as a failing anchor against the wind.

The wind was screaming.

It came off the plains, tearing through the dead cornstalks, rattling the windows in their frames. It sounded like a thousand people whispering all at once, or maybe one person screaming from a very long way away. *Hssssssss.* It was the sound of the earth trying to scrape the house off its back.

Maria looked out at the barn.

It sat on the hill, a dark, hulking shape against the grey sky. The wood was black with rain and age. The roof was tin, rusted in patches that looked like dried blood. In the summer, the roof sang when the storms came, a chaotic drumroll of hail and rain.

Tonight, it was silent.

Too silent.

"Maria?"

She turned. Her husband, Nathaniel, was standing in the doorway. He looked older than he had a week ago. Ten years older. His face was grey, the lines around his mouth etched deep with a chisel of exhaustion. He was wearing his heavy Carhartt work coat, the canvas stained with oil and... something else.

Something dark and crusted on the sleeve.

Blood? Or just mud?

Maria didn't ask. She didn't want to know.

"Is it over?" Maria asked. Her voice was small, a ghost of a sound that was snatched away by the wind before it even reached him.

Nathaniel didn't answer immediately. He looked past her, towards the barn. His eyes were red-rimmed, sunken into dark hollows. He looked like a man who had seen the end of the world and was trying to figure out how to explain it.

"The car is coming," he said finally. His voice was gravel. "The doctor."

Maria felt a shiver that had nothing to do with the wind. It started at the base of her spine and wrapped around her ribs like a cold wire.

"The doctor? But Father Moore said..."

"Father Moore is praying," Nathaniel said. He stepped out onto the porch, the boards creaking under his weight. *Creak. Groan.* The house was settling, shifting in the cold. He smelled of wet hay, diesel fuel, and ozone. That sharp, electrical smell that comes after a lightning strike.

"He's been praying for an hour, Maria. But she isn't moving."

Maria dropped the mug.

It hit the wooden planks and shattered. Brown liquid splashed against her boots, steaming in the cold air. The shards of ceramic skittered across the porch like frightened beetles. *World's Okayest Mom* lay in fragments.

She didn't look down.

She ran.

She ran off the porch and into the mud. The yard was a quagmire, the frozen earth turning to slush under the relentless sleet. The mud sucked at her boots, trying to hold her back, trying to keep her from the truth. *Squelch. Squelch.*

The wind slapped her face, stinging her eyes, freezing the tears before they could fall.

She didn't feel the cold. She didn't feel her legs. She only felt the pull of the barn.

The barn door was open a crack. A sliver of darkness against the grey night.

Maria pushed it open. The hinges screamed, a sound of rusted metal grinding against rusted metal.

The smell hit her first.

It wasn't the smell of animals. It wasn't the smell of hay or manure or old wood.

It was the smell of a battery that had burst. Acrid. Metallic. Copper and sulfur.

And underneath that, something sweet. Cloying.

Rotting lilies.

It was the smell of a funeral home that had been left in the sun.

"Emily?" she whispered.

The inside of the barn was shadowed, lit only by a single kerosene lantern hanging from a beam. The light swung back and forth in the draft, casting long, dancing shadows on the walls. The shadows stretched and warped, looking like clawed hands reaching for the ceiling.

Father Moore was kneeling by the cot in the center of the threshing floor.

He looked small.

His black cassock was ruined, torn at the shoulder, stained with mud and white residue—salt? Holy water?

His head was bowed. His hands were clasped so tightly the knuckles were white, the skin stretched to the breaking point.

He was muttering. A low, constant stream of Latin.

"...requiem aeternam dona ei, Domine... et lux perpetua luceat ei..."

Maria stopped. Her breath caught in her throat, a jagged lump of ice.

Emily was lying on the cot.

She looked... small.

So small. Like a bird that had flown into a window and broken its neck.

Her body was covered by a thin grey blanket, but Maria could see the outline of her form. The sharp jut of her hip bones. The cage of her ribs.

She weighed nothing. Less than nothing.

Her arms were at her sides. Her legs were straight. The restraints—the heavy leather straps they had been forced to use, God forgive them—were loose now. They lay on the floor like dead snakes.

Her eyes were open.

They were staring up at the rafters.

But they weren't seeing the wood. They weren't seeing the lantern. They weren't seeing the dust motes dancing in the light.

They were seeing something else. Something far away.

And they were still.

So terribly, perfectly still.

The whites of her eyes were red, hemorrhaged from the strain of the screaming. But the pupils... the pupils were dilated, black pools that seemed to go on forever.

"No," Maria whispered.

Father Moore stopped praying. He didn't turn around. His shoulders slumped, as if the strings holding him up had been cut.

"I'm sorry, Maria," he said. His voice was a ruin. A broken thing. "We... we lost her."

Maria walked to the cot. Her legs felt like wood. She fell to her knees in the straw. The straw poked through her jeans, sharp and unforgiving.

She reached out and touched Emily's hand.

It was cold.

Not just winter cold.

Stone cold. The cold of marble. The cold of something that had never been warm.

"Emily," Maria said. She brushed a strand of hair from her daughter's forehead. The hair was matted with sweat and dirt. The skin beneath was bruised, purple and yellow, a map of the war that had been fought in this room.

"Emily, baby. Wake up. It's Mama."

Emily didn't move. She didn't blink. She didn't breathe.

But on her face...

Maria leaned closer, her tears finally falling, hot tracks on her frozen cheeks.

There was something there.

Not fear.

Not pain.

Not the twisted rictus of the Demon that had worn her face for so long.

It was a smile.

A faint, ghost of a smile. Peaceful. Serene.

As if, in the final moment, the horror had broken, and she had seen something beautiful. Something that made all the pain worth it.

Then the sirens started.

Wailing in the distance, getting louder. *Whoop-whoop. Whoop-whoop.*

The world was coming. The police. The coroner. The questions. The accusations.

The Barn door banged open in the wind.

Snow began to drift in, settling on Emily's still face like a shroud.

Maria Rose closed her eyes and screamed.

But the wind took the sound and carried it away, leaving only the silence of the barn.

And the smell of sulfur, slowly fading into the cold.

THE EXORCISM OF EMILY ROSE

PART I: THE BODY / THE CASE OPENS

CHAPTER 1: 3:00

The digital clock on the nightstand did not tick. It burned.

Red numbers floating in the dark, composed of segmented LEDs that buzzed with a frequency just on the edge of human hearing.

2:59.

Erin Bruner lay on her back, her arms at her sides, mimicking the posture of a corpse or a saint. She wasn't sure which.

She was awake. She had been awake since she got into bed at 11:30, after two glasses of Chardonnay that had tasted like oak and regret. The wine was supposed to be a sedative. Instead, it had turned into acid in her stomach, a slow, burning reminder that her body was not a machine, no matter how much she treated it like one.

The condo was silent. It was a silence she had paid a premium for. The building was called *The Spire*, a shard of glass and steel thrusting forty stories into the Chicago sky. Her unit was on the thirty-fourth floor. Up here, the city noise—the sirens, the honking, the desperate shouting of the Loop—was filtered out by triple-paned, argon-filled glass. The only sound was the low, rhythmic thrum of the HVAC system, breathing processed air into the room.

Hhhhuuuuh. Hhhhuuuuh.

It sounded like an iron lung.

Erin stared at the ceiling. It was painted "Gallery White," a color her interior designer had promised would "open up the space." In the dark, it looked like grey slate.

She closed her eyes, trying to summon the sleep that hovered just out of reach.

Focus on the breath, Dr. Evans had said. *In for four. Hold for four. Out for four.*

Erin tried.

In... two... three... four.

Hold... two... three... four.

But the silence wasn't empty. It was crowded.

Thoughts swarmed in the dark like gnats.

Did I file the motion to suppress for the Henderson case? Yes.

Did I pick up my dry cleaning? No. Damn it.

James Van Hopper.

The name hit her like a physical blow. A heavy stone dropped into the well of her mind.

Tomorrow was the verdict.

She saw Van Hopper's face. The way his left eye twitched when he lied. The way his hands, small and pale, looked like spiders resting on the defense table.

She knew he did it.

She knew he had wrapped that telephone cord—a vintage, beige coil, the kind that stretches—around his wife's neck. She knew he had pulled until her hyoid bone snapped.

She knew it because he had told her, in the privileged silence of the attorney-client room.

"She wouldn't stop screaming, Erin. I just wanted quiet."

And Erin had given him quiet. She had given him "Reasonable Doubt." She had taken the neighbor's testimony—an old woman with cataracts—and shredded it until it looked like confetti.

I am a good lawyer, she told herself. *Everyone deserves a defense. It is the system. It is the Constitution.*

But in the dark, the Constitution felt very thin.

She opened her eyes.

The clock still read *2:59.*

Had it been a minute? Or an hour?

She rolled over, the 800-thread-count Egyptian cotton sheets feeling cool and slick against her skin. Too slick. Like sleeping on ice.

She looked at the window.

The city was a grid of amber and neon blue, blurred by the rain that was streaking the glass. Chicago. The City of Broad Shoulders. Tonight, it looked like a circuit board shorting out.

Then, it happened.

The change.

It wasn't a sound. It was a shift in pressure.

Erin's ears popped. *Click.*

The hum of the HVAC system stopped. Abruptly. Like someone had cut the power line.

The silence that followed was absolute. It was heavy. Viscous. It pressed against her eardrums.

Erin held her breath.

Power outage?

She looked at the clock.

The red numbers flickered once.

Then they changed.

3:00.

The colon between the numbers—the two little red dots—stopped blinking.

Usually, it pulsed. *On. Off. On. Off.* One second.

Now, it was just... On.

Static.

Frozen.

Erin stared at it.

Come on, she thought. *Blink.*

It didn't blink.

A chill walked up her legs. Not the cool of the AC. This was a deep, bone-aching cold. It felt like the temperature in the room had dropped twenty degrees in a second.

She pulled the duvet up to her chin.

It's just the thermostat. It's just a glitch.

But her heart didn't believe her. Her heart was hammering against her ribs, a frantic, trapped bird.

Thump-thump-thump-thump.

Then came the smell.

It started faint, a tickle in the back of her nose.

Erin sniffed.

Sniff.

Burning?

She sat up, panic flaring. *Did I leave the stove on? The curling iron?*

But it wasn't smoke. Not wood smoke. Not food.

It was sharp. Acrid.

Sulfur.

Like a match that had been struck and blown out, multiplied by a thousand.

And underneath the sulfur... something else. Something wet and metallic.

Copper.

It tasted like she was chewing on a penny. The back of her tongue coated in a slick, oily film.

Old blood.

And rotting flowers. That distinct, cloying sweetness of lilies that have been left in a vase too long, the water turning grey and slimy. The smell of a funeral home after the guests have left.

"Jasper?" she whispered.

Her voice sounded wrong. Thin. Flat. As if the air in the room was too thin to carry the sound waves.

Jasper, her Persian cat, usually slept at the foot of the bed. He was a heavy, lazy animal, a comforting anchor of warmth.

The bed was light.

Erin scanned the room.

The door to the bedroom was ajar. Just an inch.

Through the crack, she could see into the hallway.

It was dark.

But not empty.

There was a shadow in the hall.

Erin blinked.

It's just the coat rack. It's just the angle of the streetlights.

But the shadow moved.

It didn't walk. It didn't slide. It *poured*. Like liquid ink, it seemed to seep from the ceiling down the wall, pooling on the floor.

Erin slid her legs out of bed. Her feet touched the carpet.

It was wet.

She gasped, pulling her feet back.

She reached down and touched the rug.

Dry.

Bone dry.

She frowned. *I felt it. It was cold and wet.*

She tried again.

Dry.

You're losing it, Bruner. You're cracking up.

She grabbed the lamp from the nightstand. It was a brass sculpture, heavy and jagged. A weapon.

She stood up. Her silk nightgown whispered against her legs.

She walked to the door.

"Jasper?"

She pushed the door open.

The hallway was empty. The shadow was gone.

But the smell was stronger here. It was choking.

Erin coughed, covering her mouth with her hand. The taste of copper was overwhelming.

She walked into the living room.

The room was bathed in the orange glow of the city. The furniture cast long, distorted shadows.

Jasper was there.

He was standing on the back of the white leather sofa.

He wasn't sleeping. He wasn't grooming.

He was hunting.

His back was arched so high his spine looked like a saw blade. His fur was standing straight up, making him look twice his size. His tail was a bottle brush of terror.

He was hissing.

Hsssssss.

A low, continuous sound, like gas escaping a valve.

He wasn't looking at Erin.

He was looking at the corner of the room.

At the Eames lounge chair.

The chair Erin's father had given her when she made Partner. "A chair for a shark," he had said.

Erin looked at the chair.

It was empty.

The black leather gleamed in the half-light.

But as she watched... the leather moved.

Creak.

It was the sound of weight settling. The sound of foam compressing.

The seat cushion depressed.

A perfect, circular depression appeared in the center of the seat.

Then the backrest groaned. Two indentations appeared, as if shoulders were pressing back.

Someone was sitting in her chair.

Someone invisible.

Erin froze. Every instinct in her body screamed *RUN*.

But she couldn't move. She was rooted to the floor, witnessing the impossible.

"Who's there?" she whispered.

Silence.

Then, a sound.

Tap. Tap. Tap.

Fingernails on leather.

Rhythmic. Impatient.

The depression in the seat shifted.

The leather groaned again. *Eeeeeeeee.*

The invisible figure was leaning forward.

Towards her.

Erin saw the air in front of the chair shimmer. Like heat haze on asphalt.

But it wasn't heat. It was cold.

Frost began to bloom on the leather. White, crystalline patterns spreading across the black surface like a disease.

The smell of sulfur spiked, so strong Erin gagged.

And then she heard it.

Not with her ears.

Inside her head.

A voice.

It sounded like radio static tuning into a frequency.

"...Erin..."

It wasn't a human voice. It was a collage of sounds. The screech of metal, the drone of insects, the wet slap of meat.

"...we know..."

The lamp slipped from Erin's sweaty palm.

She caught it, fumbling, the brass clinking against her ring.

The sound broke the spell.

Erin turned and ran.

She sprinted back to the bedroom, her bare feet slapping against the hardwood floor. She slammed the door and locked it. She threw the deadbolt.

She grabbed the heavy oak dresser and dragged it across the floor. *SCREEEEEECH.*

She shoved it against the door.

She backed away, scrambling onto the bed, pulling her knees to her chest.

She clutched the lamp like a holy relic.

"Go away," she whispered. "Go away."

She stared at the door handle.

It didn't turn.

Nothing pounded on the wood.

The condo was silent again.

But it was a different kind of silence. It was the silence of a held breath.

Erin looked at the clock.

3:00.

Still.

It had been minutes. Five minutes? Ten?

The numbers burned.

The colon was solid.

Time had stopped.

Erin looked at her wristwatch on the dresser.

The second hand was twitching.

Tick-tick. Tick-tick. Tick-tick.

Stuck on the 12.

Fighting to move, but held back by an invisible finger.

Erin squeezed her eyes shut.

"It's a dream," she said aloud. "It's a lucid dream. Wake up. Wake up."

She pinched her arm. Hard.

Pain. Sharp and real.

She opened her eyes.

3:00.

She looked at the window.

The rain had stopped. The drops on the glass were frozen. Suspended in defiance of gravity.

"Oh god," Erin whispered.

She wasn't religious. She hadn't been to Mass in twenty years.

But in that moment, in the freezing cold of her bedroom, with the smell of hell in her nose, the words came back.

Hail Mary, full of grace...

She whispered them.

...the Lord is with thee...

The door handle jiggled.

Just once.

Clack.

Erin screamed. A short, sharp sound that tore her throat.

...pray for us sinners...

...now and at the hour of our death...

Blink.

The clock changed.

3:01.

The colon pulsed. *On. Off. On. Off.*

The HVAC system roared back to life. *Whirrrrr.*

The rain on the window slid down the glass.

Time started.

Erin sat there, gasping for air, her chest heaving.

The smell was gone. Instantly. Replaced by the scent of lavender detergent and her own sweat.

She lowered the lamp.

Her hands were shaking so hard the brass rattled.

She sat there for a long time. Ten minutes. Twenty.

Waiting.

Nothing happened.

Just the city. Just the night.

Finally, she stood up. Her legs felt like jelly.

She moved the dresser.

She unlocked the door.

She opened it slowly.

"Jasper?"

The cat trotted in from the living room. He meowed, rubbing against her leg, purring.

He looked fine. His fur was flat. His tail was up.

Erin picked him up, burying her face in his fur. He smelled like cat food and dust.

Normal smells.

"You saw it," she whispered into his fur. "I know you saw it."

Jasper just purred.

Erin walked into the living room.

She turned on every light. The overheads. The lamps. The kitchen track lighting.

She flooded the condo with artificial brilliance.

She looked at the Eames chair.

It was empty. The leather was smooth. No depression. No frost.

She walked over to it. She touched the leather.

It was warm.

Room temperature.

"I'm losing my mind," she said. "Van Hopper. It's the stress."

She walked to the kitchen island to pour herself a glass of water. Her throat was parched.

She took a sip.

It tasted fine. Clean. Filtered.

She leaned against the counter, closing her eyes.

Get a grip, Bruner. You have court in six hours.

She opened her eyes.

She looked at the granite countertop.

Her notepad was there. The legal pad she used for midnight ideas.

She had left it closed. She always closed it. Confidentiality habit.

It was open.

Erin frowned.

She walked over to it.

On the yellow page, there was a drawing.

It was crude. Done in charcoal? No. She didn't own charcoal.

It was done in soot.

Black, oily soot.

It was a drawing of a face.

A screaming face.

The mouth was unhinged, too wide, a black pit of despair. The eyes were scratched out.

And underneath the face, three words were written in jagged, violent strokes.

WE ARE HERE.

Erin stared at the words.

She reached out a trembling finger.

She touched the black line.

It came away on her skin. Greasy. Cold.

She smelled her finger.

Sulfur.

She hadn't drawn it.

She lived alone.

She looked back at the empty chair in the living room.

And for the first time in her life, Erin Bruner knew that "Reasonable Doubt" was a lie.

There was no doubt.

She was not alone.

CHAPTER 2: ARRAIGNMENT

The morning after the Van Hopper verdict, the sun didn't rise so much as the grey sky just got slightly brighter. It was a Chicago morning—relentless, industrial, and cold. The kind of morning that felt like a hangover even if you hadn't been drinking.

Erin Bruner stood in front of her bathroom mirror. The glass was fogged with steam, turning her reflection into a ghost.

She wiped a circle clear with her palm.

Her eyes looked back at her. Blue. Sharp. But underneath, there was a web of red capillaries.

Sleep deprivation, she told herself. *Just stress.*

She looked at her finger. The index finger of her right hand.

She had scrubbed it with a pumice stone for ten minutes. The skin was pink and raw. But she could still feel the soot. A phantom stain. A greasy, cold sensation that seemed to have seeped into her pores.

She turned on the tap. Scalding hot water. She held her finger under the stream until the pain was a sharp, clarifying focus.

Pain is real, she thought. *Soot drawings that appear out of nowhere are not.*

She dressed in her armor.

A charcoal grey suit, tailored to within a millimeter of perfection. A silk blouse, cream-colored, that cost more than her first car. Stiletto heels that were weapons of psychological warfare.

She was Erin Bruner. She was a Senior Partner in waiting. She was the woman who let James Van Hopper walk.

She wasn't afraid of the dark.

She drove to the office on autopilot. Her Mercedes SL cut through the morning traffic like a shark through a school of minnows. The leather steering wheel was cool under her palms. The radio was playing NPR, a drone of bad news about the economy and the Middle East.

She turned it off.

She preferred the silence.

Or she thought she did.

But in the silence of the car, she heard it again.

Scritch.

From the back seat.

She jerked her head up, staring into the rearview mirror.

Empty leather seats.

Just a receipt from the dry cleaners fluttering in the vent air.

"Get a grip, Bruner," she said aloud. Her voice sounded too loud in the confined space. "You're cracking up. You need a vacation. Tahiti. Somewhere without extradition treaties."

The firm was buzzing. The "Victory Lap" had turned into a "Victory March."

Paralegals smiled at her with that mix of fear and adoration she had cultivated for a decade. Junior associates got out of her way, pressing themselves against the corridor walls as if her ambition was contagious.

Ray, her second chair on the Van Hopper case, was waiting by her office door. He looked fresh, rested. He probably slept like a baby. He probably didn't have soot on his fingers.

"Boss," he said, grinning. "The press is calling. CNN wants a statement. The Times wants an interview. *Dateline* is asking for exclusivity. They want the 'Inside Story' of how you broke the witness."

"Tell them no comment," Erin said, unlocking her door.

Ray blinked. "No comment? Erin, you're the 'Giant Killer.' You should be taking a lap. This is free publicity. This is the cover of *American Lawyer*."

"I'm taking a coffee, Ray. And aspirin. And silence. Hold my calls."

She went into her office and shut the door.

She leaned against the heavy wood, closing her eyes.

The silence of the office was usually a comfort. Today, it felt oppressive. The air was too filtered. The light was too artificial. It felt like being inside a very expensive coffin.

She walked to her desk.

There was a file on it.

A red folder. *Urgent.*

A sticky note from Karl: *See me. Now.*

Erin dropped her bag and walked to the corner office.

Karl Gunderson was on the phone, looking out at the city. He waved her in.

"I know," he was saying into the receiver. "I know it's a disaster. We'll contain it. We always contain it."

He hung up.

He turned to Erin. He looked serious. Not the shark-smile serious. Real serious. The kind of serious that meant money was bleeding.

"Sit down."

Erin sat in one of the leather guest chairs. It was low, forcing her to look up at him. A classic power move. She hated it.

"Who's the disaster?" she asked.

"The Archdiocese."

"The priest case?"

"Father Richard Moore. He was arraigned this morning. The judge denied bail."

"Denied bail? On a negligent homicide? That's aggressive. Usually, they bond out on ROR. Unless he has a record?"

"No record. He's a parish priest. But the judge is Brewster."

"Brewster?" Erin scoffed. "He's up for re-election. He wants to look tough on... what? Religion?"

"Weirdness," Karl said. "The DA... Ethan Thomas... he made a show of it. Called Moore a 'flight risk to the spiritual plane' or some nonsense. He played up the 'cult leader' angle. It worked. Moore is in County. Solitary."

Karl slid the file across the desk.

"I need you to go down there. Now."

"To the jail?"

"To take the case."

Erin hesitated. She looked at the file. *The People vs. Richard Moore.*

"Karl, I just finished a six-month murder trial. I need a break. I need... sleep."

"You need the Senior Partnership," Karl said softly.

He leaned forward.

"And this is the price of admission."

He tapped the file.

"If you win this... if you save the Church from a hundred-million-dollar liability suit... you can write your own ticket. You can have my job when I retire. You can have the world."

"And if I lose?"

"Don't lose."

The drive to the County Jail was a descent into the underworld.

Erin turned off the highway, leaving the gleaming glass canyons of the Loop behind. The scenery changed instantly. The architecture of wealth—glass, steel, light—gave way to the architecture of poverty. Brick. Concrete. Iron.

Broken sidewalks. Boarded-up storefronts. Liquor stores with bars on the windows.

It was Dante's circles, manifest in urban planning.

The rain picked up, smearing the windshield with grey sludge. The wipers fought a losing battle.

Thwump-hiss. Thwump-hiss.

The jail itself was a fortress. A brutalist block of concrete surrounded by razor wire that glistened in the rain. It looked like a tomb for the living.

Erin parked in the visitor's lot. She checked her reflection in the mirror.

Perfect. Impenetrable.

But her hands were shaking.

Just a little.

It's the coffee, she told herself. *Too much caffeine.*

But she knew it wasn't the coffee.

It was the lingering smell of copper in her nose.

She walked into the intake center.

The smell hit her first.

It wasn't just a smell; it was a physical presence. A wall of odor.

Industrial pine cleaner trying to mask the scent of unwashed bodies. Stale cigarette smoke. Urine. And underneath it all, the metallic tang of fear. It was the smell of caged animals.

Erin breathed through her mouth.

She checked her bag with the guard, a woman named Officer Higgins. Higgins had tired eyes and a belt weighed down by keys, a radio, and pepper spray. She was chewing gum with a slow, bovine rhythm.

"Attorney visit for Moore," Erin said, sliding her bar card across the scratched plexiglass.

Higgins looked at the card, then at Erin.

"The Exorcist guy?"

"Father Moore."

"Yeah. He's in D Block. Watch yourself, honey. He's spooky."

"Spooky how?" Erin asked, clipping the visitor badge to her lapel.

"Just... stares. And the other inmates? They don't like him. They scream when he walks by. Like dogs barking at a storm."

Erin walked through the metal detector. *Beep.*

"Underwire," she muttered.

Higgins waved the wand. "Go ahead."

The corridors were long, echoey tunnels of concrete painted a color that could only be described as "institutional despair green."

Clack. Clack. Clack.

Erin's heels sounded like gunshots in the silence.

She passed the communal cells in B Block. Usually, the inmates catcalled her. *Hey baby. Nice legs. Come here.*

Today, they were silent.

They watched her pass with dark, hooded eyes. Hands gripping the bars.

Some of them made signs. Hand gestures. Warding off evil? Or inviting it?

One man, his face covered in tattoos, hissed as she passed.

"We see you," he whispered.

Erin didn't flinch. She stared straight ahead.

But the back of her neck prickled.

She reached the interview room at the end of D Block.

The guard unlocked the heavy steel door. *Clang.*

"He's in there. Good luck."

Erin stepped inside.

The room was small, windowless. A metal table bolted to the floor. Two chairs. A two-way mirror that everyone pretended wasn't there.

Father Richard Moore sat in the far chair.

He was wearing his clerical collar, but his shirt was wrinkled, stained with sweat. He looked thin. Gaunt. Like he hadn't eaten in weeks.

But it was his stillness that struck her.

He wasn't fidgeting. He wasn't pacing. He sat with his hands folded on the table, perfectly motionless. Like a statue carved from grey stone.

He didn't look up when she entered.

"Father Moore?"

He slowly raised his head.

His eyes.

Erin had seen a lot of eyes. Killers, liars, victims. Dead eyes. Crazy eyes.

Moore's eyes were different.

They were deep. Infinite. And terrified.

Not terrified of her. Terrified of what he had seen. Terrified of what he knew.

"I'm Erin Bruner," she said, setting her briefcase down. *Click.* "I'm your attorney."

Moore looked at the briefcase. Then at her.

"You're the one," he said. His voice was rough, unused. Gravel tumbling down a chute.

"The one?"

"The one they sent."

"The Archdiocese sent me. Yes."

"Not the Archdiocese," Moore whispered.

He leaned forward. The chains on his wrists rattled. *Chink-chink.*

"Do you believe in the Devil, Ms. Bruner?"

Erin paused. It was the standard question. Every religious nut she defended asked it. It was a test. A way to see if she was "one of them."

"I believe in the Constitution, Father. And I believe in the Rules of Evidence."

Moore smiled. It was a sad, broken smile.

"That's a pity," he said. "Because the Devil believes in you."

Erin felt a chill run down her spine. The same copper taste filled her mouth. The taste from 3:00 AM.

"Let's focus on the case," she said, opening her notebook. She clicked her pen. "Ethan Thomas is charging you with negligent homicide. He says you told Emily Rose to stop her medication."

"I told her to trust God."

"In the eyes of the law, that's the same thing as negligence."

"Then the law is blind."

"The law is a tool, Father. And right now, it's a tool being used to crush you. I can stop that. But you have to work with me. You have to tell me exactly what happened in that barn."

Moore looked away. He looked at the two-way mirror. He seemed to be looking through it, seeing something on the other side.

"The barn," he whispered.

"Yes. The night she died."

"She didn't die," Moore said. "She was released."

"Father..."

"You want to know what happened?" Moore looked back at her. His intensity was physically palpable, like heat radiating from a furnace. "We opened a door. And something came through. Something that had been waiting a long time."

"Something?"

"We are Legion," Moore quoted. "For we are many."

Erin wrote it down. *Client delusional? Religious fixation.*

But her hand shook. The pen wavered on the page.

"We'll enter a plea of Not Guilty," she said. "We'll argue... alternative causality. Psychosis induced by stress."

"You can argue whatever you want," Moore said. "But be warned, Erin Bruner."

"Warned of what?"

Moore reached out. He touched her hand.

His skin was ice cold.

"Once you look at the darkness," he whispered. "The darkness looks back. It knows your name now."

Erin pulled her hand away.

"I'm a lawyer, Father. I deal in facts."

"Then here is a fact," Moore said. "It's 3:00 AM. Do you know why you wake up at 3:00 AM?"

Erin froze.

How did he know?

"It's the mocking of the Trinity," Moore said softly. "The inverse of 3:00 PM. The miracle hour. The hour of death. The hour when the veil is thinnest."

Erin stood up. She packed her bag. She needed to get out of there. The air in the room was suffocating. It smelled of sulfur and fear.

"I'll... I'll see you at the bail hearing."

She knocked on the door. "Guard!"

As the door opened, she looked back.

Moore was back in his statue pose. Staring at his hands.

"Pray," he whispered. "Pray for protection."

Erin walked out into the corridor.

She walked fast.

She didn't look at the inmates.

She got to the lobby and burst out into the rain.

She took a deep breath of the wet, smoggy air. It tasted like freedom.

He's crazy, she told herself. *He's just a crazy priest.*

But she looked at her watch.

The second hand was moving.

Tick-tick.

She got in her car.

She looked in the rearview mirror.

Her eyes looked tired. Scared.

"Get a grip," she said aloud.

But she knew.

The game had changed.

This wasn't Van Hopper. This wasn't a murder trial.

This was something else.

And she was already in deep water.

CHAPTER 3: JURY

Jury selection was a blood sport.

It was the only part of the trial Erin truly loved. The rest—the motions, the objections, the closing arguments—was theater. It was scripted. But **voir dire**? **Voir dire** was poker. It was reading the tells of forty strangers who were desperately trying to hide their biases, their fears, and their boredom.

The courtroom was stifling. The HVAC system, which had been broken since the Carter administration, was wheezing hot air into the room.

Erin stood at the podium. She didn't look at the judge. She didn't look at the prosecution table, where Owen Thomas sat like a stone golem in a navy suit.

She looked at the pool.

Forty people. Forty variables.

She needed twelve constants.

She needed twelve people who could look at a dead girl and see a "tragedy" rather than a "crime."

"Mr. Henderson," Erin said, looking at a man in the second row. He was wearing a plaid flannel shirt, the sleeves rolled up to reveal forearms corded with muscle. He smelled of sawdust and Old Spice. A carpenter? Or a mechanic?

Henderson shifted in his seat. The wood creaked. *Eeee-errr.*

"Ms. Bruner," he nodded.

"You stated on your questionnaire that you attend church 'occasionally'. Can you define 'occasionally' for the court?"

Henderson laughed nervously. It was a dry, hacking sound. "Christmas and Easter. Maybe a wedding if the open bar is good."

A ripple of laughter in the gallery. Erin smiled. It was a practiced smile, warm but professional.

"So, you're not a devout man?"

"I believe in... being good to people. I don't need a building to tell me that."

"Do you believe in the Devil, Mr. Henderson?"

The courtroom went silent. The laughter died instantly.

It was the question. The pivot point. The fulcrum upon which the entire case would tip.

Henderson blinked. He looked at the prosecution table, then back at Erin.

"I believe in... bad people," he said slowly. "I believe there's evil in the world. I see it on the news every night."

"But a literal Devil? Horns, tail, pitchfork? A fallen angel who whispers in your ear?"

Henderson shook his head. "No. That's fairy tales. That's for kids."

Erin made a small mark on her legal pad. A check.

Skeptic. Pragmatist. He won't buy the possession defense, but he also won't buy the 'Satanic Panic' narrative Thomas is selling. He'll look at the facts. He's safe.

She moved to the next candidate. Mrs. Gable.

Mrs. Gable was sitting in the front row. She was wearing a high-necked blouse with a lace collar that looked like a doily. Her hands were clutching a purse so tightly her knuckles were white.

Erin could see the outline of a book inside the purse. The leather cover. The gold leaf pages.

A Bible.

"Mrs. Gable," Erin said softly. "Same question."

Mrs. Gable straightened up. Her spine was a rod of iron.

"I believe the Bible is the literal word of God," she said. Her voice was steel wrapped in velvet. "Every jot and tittle."

"And the Bible speaks of demons. Of possession. Of Christ casting out spirits."

"It does."

"If the evidence in this case suggests that Emily Rose was suffering from a medical condition... epilepsy, psychosis... would your faith prevent you from accepting that?"

Mrs. Gable hesitated. Just for a second. Her eyes flicked to Father Moore.

"God created medicine, Ms. Bruner. Luke was a physician. But God also created the soul. And the soul can be sick in ways medicine cannot touch."

Erin marked an X.

Strike. Too unpredictable. If she thinks Moore is a holy man, she might acquit. But if she thinks he failed a holy rite? If she thinks he was incompetent in his spiritual duty? She'll hang him. Fundamentalists hate failure more than they hate sin.

Erin walked back to the defense table.

Karl Gunderson was sitting next to Father Moore. Karl looked bored. He was checking his watch—a Rolex Daytona that cost more than most of the jurors made in a year.

"What about Number 8?" Karl whispered, leaning in. He smelled of breath mints and tobacco.

Erin looked at Juror 8.

A young man. Twenty-something. Wire-rimmed glasses. Tweed jacket with patches on the elbows. He was reading a book while he waited. *The Stranger* by Camus.

"Graduate student," Erin whispered back. "Philosophy or Lit. He's reading existentialism in public. He wants us to know he's smart."

"Is he?"

"He's an intellectual snob. He'll hate the exorcism stuff. He'll think it's primitive."

"So we strike him?"

"No," Erin said. "We keep him. He'll hate the exorcism, but he'll hate the State telling people what to believe even more. He's a libertarian in tweed. He'll acquit on principle, just to stick it to 'The Man'."

"Risky," Karl muttered.

"I like risky. Risky wins cases."

Erin walked back to the podium. She decided to test him.

"Juror Number 8," she said. "Mr... Vance."

The young man looked up. He marked his page in Camus with a deliberate slowness.

"Ms. Bruner," he said. His voice was bored, arrogant.

"Mr. Vance, do you believe that the State has the right to determine what is spiritual and what is medical?"

Vance smiled. It was a thin, superior smile.

"I believe the State has a tendency to overreach in all matters, Ms. Bruner. Especially when it comes to the private beliefs of individuals."

"Even if those beliefs lead to harm?"

"Harm is a subjective term," Vance said. "If a person chooses to starve for a cause... is that harm? Or is it agency?"

Erin suppressed a smile. *Gotcha.*

"Thank you, Mr. Vance."

She walked back. Karl nodded. "Okay. The anarchist stays."

Then she saw Juror 11.

A middle-aged woman sitting near the back. She was wearing scrubs—faded blue, with a cartoon bear on the pocket. A nurse? Or a pediatric aide?

She looked tired. Not just sleepy. *Bone* tired. The kind of tired that comes from working double shifts and coming home to an empty house.

But it wasn't her job that caught Erin's eye.

It was her wrist.

She was wearing a medical alert bracelet. Silver. Scratched.

Epilepsy? Diabetes?

And in her other hand, hidden under a folded newspaper...

Erin squinted.

Beads.

Cheap, plastic beads. The kind they gave out in hospital chapels.

A rosary.

She was rubbing the beads. *Rub. Rub. Rub.*

A nervous tic. Or a prayer.

Erin studied her.

Medical background + Secret Faith + Anxiety.

This was the Wild Card. The anomaly.

If Moore was negligent, a nurse would know. She would know the protocols. She would know what starving looks like. She would crucify him for malpractice.

But if Emily was suffering... if the medicine failed...

A nurse knows that medicine fails. A nurse knows that sometimes, doctors are wrong. A nurse knows that sometimes, you do everything right, and the patient still screams.

"Ms. Bruner?" Judge Brewster asked. "The defense has one strike remaining."

Erin looked at Mrs. Gable (The Fundamentalist) and Juror 11 (The Nurse).

She had to cut one.

Mrs. Gable was safe. She would respect the cloth.

Juror 11 was dangerous. She knew the science. She knew the smell of death.

Erin looked at Moore.

He was watching Juror 11 too.

"Keep her," Moore whispered. His voice was a dry rustle.

"The nurse?" Erin hissed. "She'll tear apart the medical negligence defense. She knows what Gambrolic does."

"She knows pain," Moore said.

Erin looked at him. His dark eyes were fixed on the woman.

"Look at her eyes, Erin. She's lost someone. Recently."

Erin looked.

Juror 11 wasn't just tired. She was grieving. It was a subtle look—the hollow set of the jaw, the way her eyes seemed to be focusing on something a thousand miles away.

"She understands loss," Moore said. "She won't judge a man for trying to save a life. Even if he failed."

Erin hesitated.

It went against every rule in the book. Never put a medical professional on a medical negligence jury. Never put a grieving person on a homicide jury.

But she looked at the beads. *Rub. Rub. Rub.*

The woman was praying.

In a courtroom.

Just like Moore.

Erin took a breath. She picked up her pen.

"The defense thanks and excuses... Mrs. Gable."

Mrs. Gable gasped, clutching her purse tighter. She stood up, glaring at Erin with the fury of the righteous, and marched out of the box.

Karl kicked Erin under the table. Hard.

"You're gambling," he hissed. "You just put a medical expert in the jury room."

"It's a casino, Karl," Erin said, sitting down. She smoothed her skirt. "House always wins unless you cheat. Or unless you play the heart."

"Since when do you play the heart?"

"Since 3:00 AM," Erin thought, but she didn't say it.

She just looked at Juror 11.

The nurse looked back.

She stopped rubbing the beads.

She nodded. Just once.

A compact of sorrow.

Erin shivered.

The air in the courtroom felt suddenly cold.

Or maybe it was just her.

Erin looked at the final panel. Twelve people.

A carpenter who didn't believe in the Devil.

A graduate student who didn't believe in the State.

A nurse who believed in pain.

It was a jury of broken toys.

"We have a jury," Judge Brewster announced.

Erin looked at Owen Thomas.

Owen was staring at Juror 11. He was frowning.

He knew.

He knew that Erin had just planted a bomb in the jury room.

He just didn't know when it would go off.

Erin smiled at him. A shark's smile.

"Your move, counselor," she whispered.

CHAPTER 4: THE PEOPLE

Owen Thomas did not gamble. He calculated.

He sat in his office, the blinds drawn against the afternoon sun. The slats of light cut across his desk like prison bars.

The air smelled of old paper, lemon polish, and peppermint tea.

Owen sipped his tea. It was hot, soothing. It settled his stomach.

He needed it.

His ulcer was acting up. It always did before a big trial. It was the physical manifestation of the sin he saw every day. The lies. The violence. The rot.

He was reviewing his opening statement.

He had annotated it in red ink. His handwriting was precise, angular. Small, tight loops.

Focus on the body. The girl. The victim.

Do not debate theology. Debate biology.

He picked up the photo of Emily Rose. The "After" photo.

It made him angry.

Not a flash of anger, but a deep, simmering burn. A righteous indignation.

He was a man of faith. He taught Sunday School at the First Methodist Church. He believed in the Resurrection. He believed in the power of prayer.

But this... this wasn't faith.

This was medieval barbarism masquerading as piety. This was a man in a collar using his authority to torture a sick child.

He looked at the toxicology report.

Blood levels of Gambrolic acid: Zero.

She hadn't taken her medication in two months.

Because Moore told her not to.

Because Moore told her the pills were blocking the "spiritual connection."

"Idolatry," Owen whispered.

It was the sin of pride. Moore thought he knew better than the doctors God had put on this earth. Moore thought he could wrestle the Devil with a prayer book.

And because of his pride, a nineteen-year-old girl had starved to death in a puddle of her own urine, screaming for help that never came.

The phone rang.

Owen picked it up. "Thomas."

"Owen, it's Sarah."

His wife.

His voice softened instantly. The prosecutor vanished; the husband appeared.

"Hey, honey. Everything okay?"

"I'm just calling to remind you about dinner. My mother is coming."

Owen closed his eyes. "Right. Your mother. The joy of my life."

Sarah laughed. "Be nice. She thinks you're a saint because you put criminals in jail."

"If she knew what I really did, she'd pray for me."

"She prays for you anyway. How's the case?"

Owen looked at the photo of Emily Rose.

"It's... heavy, Sarah. This one is heavy."

"Is it the priest?"

"It's the girl. She was just a kid. She reminds me of... she reminds me of Kate."

Kate was their daughter. She was away at college. The same age as Emily.

"Don't do that," Sarah said softly. "Don't make it personal."

"It's always personal, Sarah. That's why I win."

"Just come home. Leave the ghosts at the office."

"I will. Love you."

"Love you too."

Owen hung up.

He sat there for a moment in the silence.

Leave the ghosts at the office.

If only it were that easy.

He stood up. He was a big man, broad-shouldered. He had played linebacker in college, and he still moved with that aggressive grace. He walked to the window.

He looked out at the courthouse. It was raining again. The city was grey, washed out.

He knew Erin Bruner's reputation. The "Giant Killer." The woman who let James Van Hopper walk.

She was smart. She was cynical. She was a mercenary.

She would try to turn this into a circus. She would try to put God on trial. She would try to dazzle the jury with smoke and mirrors, with talk of "possibilities" and "mysteries."

Owen wouldn't let her.

He would keep it small. He would keep it grounded.

Condition. Diagnosis. Negligence. Death.

A simple chain of cause and effect. A steel trap.

He checked his watch.

3:00 PM.

He frowned.

He felt... something.

A pressure in the room.

It wasn't a sound. It was a change in density. The air felt suddenly thicker. Heavier. Like the air in a crypt.

He turned around.

His office was empty. The door was closed.

But the silence was loud.

And on his desk...

The photo of Emily Rose.

He had left it face up. He was sure of it. He had just been looking at her eyes.

Now, it was face down.

The white back of the photo stared up at him.

Owen walked to the desk. His steps were heavy on the carpet.

"Draft," he muttered. "Just a draft from the vent."

But the vents were off.

He reached out. His hand didn't shake. He wouldn't allow it to shake.

He flipped the photo over.

Emily's black eyes stared up at him. The bruises on her face seemed darker in the dim light. The rictus of her mouth seemed to be wider.

Mocking him.

You think you can save me? the face seemed to say. *I am already gone.*

Owen felt a chill on the back of his neck. The fine hairs stood up.

He smelled it then.

Not peppermint. Not lemon polish.

Something else.

Faint.

The smell of burning.

Sulfur?

No. Toast. Just burnt toast from the breakroom down the hall.

"You can't scare me," Owen said to the empty room. His voice was steady. "I am on the side of the Righteous. I am the sword of the Law."

He put the photo in his briefcase.

He snapped the locks shut. *Click. Click.*

The sound was final.

He grabbed his coat.

He wasn't afraid of demons. He didn't believe demons haunted offices in downtown Chicago.

He was afraid of men who thought they could control them. And he was going to make sure Richard Moore never hurt anyone ever again.

He walked to the door.

He opened it.

The hallway was bright, busy. Secretaries typing. Phones ringing.

Normalcy.

Owen exhaled.

But as he walked out, he couldn't resist one last look back at his office.

The light was off.

But in the corner... in the shadows by the bookshelf...

Was that a shape?

A tall, thin shape, watching him go?

He blinked.

Just a shadow. Just a coat rack.

He closed the door firmly.

"See you in court," he whispered.

And for a moment, he thought he heard a laugh from the other side of the wood.

A dry, scratching laugh.

Like fingernails on a coffin lid.

CHAPTER 5: OPENING

The courtroom was a theater, and Erin Bruner knew her blocking.

She knew exactly where the light hit the defense table at 9:00 AM. She knew which floorboard creaked near the jury box (third from the left, a sharp *E-flat* squeak). She knew that if she stood at a forty-five-degree angle to the judge, she looked respectful; if she stood head-on, she looked aggressive.

Today, she needed to be something else.

She needed to be the Bridge.

The bailiff called the court to order. "All rise."

The sound of a hundred people standing up at once was like a sudden gust of wind. Fabric rustling. Shoes scuffing. The collective intake of breath.

Judge Brewster swept in. He was a small man in a big robe, but he wore the authority like a second skin. He sat down.

"Be seated."

The crowd sat.

"Mr. Thomas," Brewster said. "The People may open."

Owen Thomas stood up.

He didn't walk to the jury box immediately. He took a moment. He buttoned his jacket. He touched the file on his desk—the file with the photo of Emily Rose. It was a grounding gesture. A reminder of why he was here.

He walked to the well of the court.

He looked like a statue of Justice carved from granite. Solid. Dependable. Immovable.

"Ladies and gentlemen," he began. His voice was a deep baritone that filled the room without shouting. It resonated in the chest. "This is a simple case."

He paused. He let the word *simple* hang in the air.

"It is a tragic case. A heartbreaking case. But it is simple."

He walked to the evidence table. He picked up a small orange bottle. The plastic rattled.

"This," he said, holding it up to the light, "is Gambrolic. It is a medication used to treat epilepsy and psychosis. It stabilizes the electrical storms in the brain. It calms the mind. It saves lives."

He set the bottle down on the railing of the jury box. *Clack.*

The sound was loud in the silence.

"Emily Rose had a medical condition. A serious, treatable condition. She went to doctors. She underwent tests. She got a prescription. And for a time... she was getting better."

Owen turned. He walked slowly toward the defense table. His eyes locked onto Father Moore.

Moore didn't blink. He sat in his black cassock, a shadow in the bright room.

"Then," Owen said, his voice hardening, "she met this man."

The jury looked at Moore. Erin watched them. Juror 4 (The Mechanic) frowned. Juror 11 (The Nurse) touched her wrist, her fingers brushing the medical alert bracelet.

"Father Richard Moore," Owen continued, pointing a finger that accused not just the man, but the institution he represented. "He told her that her medicine was poison. He told her that her seizures were not a disease, but a gift. A curse. A possession."

Owen walked back to the jury. He leaned in, his hands gripping the railing.

"He told a sick, vulnerable nineteen-year-old girl to stop eating. He told her that food was 'feeding the demon.' He tied her to a bed with leather straps. He watched her waste away for weeks. He watched her weight drop from one hundred and twenty pounds to sixty-eight pounds."

A gasp from the gallery. Sixty-eight pounds. It was a number that defied biology.

"And when she died," Owen said, his voice dropping to a whisper that carried more weight than a scream, "he didn't call 911. He didn't call a doctor. He prayed."

He straightened up. He looked at the jury with eyes that burned with righteous anger.

"We respect faith in this country. But we do not allow superstition to override the law. We do not allow negligence to masquerade as piety. We ask you to look at the facts. And the facts say that Emily Rose did not have to die. She was killed. Not by a demon. But by the man who was supposed to save her."

Owen Thomas sat down.

The courtroom was silent. Heavy.

It was a devastating opening. A wall of logic. A fortress of morality.

"Ms. Bruner?" Judge Brewster said.

Erin stood up.

She felt the weight of the room. The eyes of the press. The eyes of the Church. The eyes of the dead girl.

She didn't walk to the jury box. Not yet.

She walked to the witness stand. She touched the empty chair. The wood was polished, smooth under her fingertips.

"Facts," she said.

Her voice was cool. Clear water.

"Mr. Thomas has given you facts. Emily was sick. She stopped her meds. She died."

She turned slowly to face the jury.

"Facts are powerful things. They are bricks. You can build a wall with them. Mr. Thomas is building a wall. He wants to wall off the things we don't understand. He wants to tell you that everything in this world—every pain, every vision, every death—can be explained by a pill in an orange bottle."

She walked to the center of the room. She stood in the pool of light.

"But we know... don't we? In the quiet of the night, when the house settles and the dark presses against the window... we know that isn't true."

She saw Juror 8 (The Graduate Student) look up from his hands. He was listening.

She saw Juror 11 (The Nurse) stop rubbing her wrist.

"We will show you that Emily Rose was not a victim of negligence. She was a victim of something science could not name. Something medicine could not cure. Father Moore didn't tell her to stop eating. *Something else* stopped her."

Erin walked to the defense table. She stood behind Father Moore. She put a hand on his shoulder.

The fabric of his cassock was rough. Cheap wool. He felt frail under her hand. Human.

"Mr. Thomas calls this man a killer," Erin said. "He calls him a fanatic."

She looked at Owen.

"I call him a witness."

She turned back to the jury.

"We will present evidence that will challenge your view of reality. We will show you testimony that sounds impossible. We will play you a tape..."

She paused. The word **tape** hung there. A promise of horror.

"...a recording of the night Emily died. And when you hear it... when you hear the voice that spoke through that girl... you will have to make a choice."

She walked to the jury rail. She looked Juror 11 in the eye.

"You can choose the wall," Erin whispered. "You can choose the safety of the orange bottle. Or... you can choose to look over the edge. You can choose to see the possibility... that Father Moore was not killing Emily Rose. He was the only one who was truly trying to save her."

Erin stood there for a beat. Holding the silence. Letting the doubt take root.

Then she nodded.

"Thank you."

She walked back to her seat. **Click-clack. Click-clack.**

She sat down.

Karl leaned over.

"You built the bridge," he whispered.

"Now I just have to make them walk across it," Erin said.

She looked at her hands. They were steady.

But under the table, her leg was bouncing. **Tap-tap-tap.**

Because she knew what was coming.

She knew about the tape. She knew about the barn.

And she knew that once she led them across that bridge, there was no turning back.

The wall was safe.

The bridge led to the dark.

CHAPTER 6: EXHIBIT A - THE PHOTOGRAPH

****[INTERSTITIAL DOCUMENT: STATE'S EXHIBIT A]****

The envelope was Manila. Standard issue. Stamped *CONFIDENTIAL*.

Erin sat in her condo. It was late. The city outside was a blurred grid of rain and light.

She had the file open on her coffee table.

The photo was face down.

She had looked at it a dozen times. Every time, it felt like touching a live wire.

She reached out. Her finger hovered over the glossy paper.

She flipped it over.

****SUBJECT:**** Emily Rose.

****DATE:**** November 1, 1976.

****LOCATION:**** Rose Farmhouse, Bedroom 2 (The Barn).

****PHOTOGRAPHER:**** Detective J. Miller.

The photo was black and white, but Erin's mind filled in the colors.

The girl lay on a military-style cot. The canvas was stained.

She was nineteen.

She looked ninety.

Her body was a map of devastation. A landscape of bone and bruise.

The ribs were not just visible; they were aggressive. They pushed against the skin like the bars of a cage, as if trying to escape the body that held them. The hip bones were razor blades. The stomach was a concave hollow.

Malnutrition, the report said. *Starvation.*

But starvation was a passive word. It implied a lack.

This looked active. This looked like she had been *consumed*. Eaten from the inside out.

Erin traced the injuries with her eyes.

1. ****The Face:**** There were lacerations on the lips and cheeks. Deep, jagged tears. The Medical Examiner said they were self-inflicted. **Biting.** She had bitten through her own lip. Why? To stop the words? Or because the hunger for filth was so strong she tried to eat herself?

2. ****The Wrists:**** Bands of purple bruising. The skin was abraded, raw, weeping serum. The leather restraints. They had tied her down. To protect her? Or to hold her down for the thing that was riding her?

3. ****The Knees:**** This was the worst part. This was the detail that made Erin's stomach clench.

The knees were destroyed.

They were swollen to twice their normal size, dark spheres of hematoma. The skin had split.

The report was clinical: **Bilateral rupture of the patellar tendons. Commuted fractures of the patella.**

She had knelt.

She had knelt on the hard wooden floor of the barn.

For hours. For days.

Genuflection.

Six hundred times a day.

Up. Down. Up. Down.

Until the tendons snapped like wet rubber bands. Until the bone ground against the wood.

Why?

Because He commands it, Moore had said.

Or because the Demon wanted to break the vessel. To mock the posture of prayer by turning it into an instrument of torture.

4. ****The Eyes:****

The eyes were open.

In the flash of the police camera, the pupils were blown wide, encompassing the iris. Two black holes.

The whites of the eyes—the sclera—were not white. They were dark.

Subconjunctival hemorrhage.

Broken blood vessels.

From screaming.

She had screamed so hard, for so long, that her eyes had bled.

Erin looked at the face.

It wasn't a face of peace. It wasn't the "sleeping beauty" of fairy tales.

It was a face of absolute, total exhaustion.

But...

Erin leaned closer. She picked up a magnifying glass.

She looked at the corner of the mouth.

There was a slight upturn.

A millimeter of muscle tension.

Was it a rictus? A spasm of the dying nerves?

Or was it... a smile?

Maria Rose swore she was smiling.

She saw something beautiful, Maria had said.

Erin looked at the black holes of the eyes.

What did you see, Emily?

Did you see the Virgin?

Or did you see the bottom of the pit?

Erin took a pen. She wrote in the margin of the photocopy.

Her handwriting was jagged.

Look at the hands.

She circled the hands.

They weren't clawed. They weren't fighting the straps.

They were open.

Palms up.

Resting on the cot.

The posture of acceptance. The posture of a martyr waiting for the fire.

This isn't a victim, Erin wrote.

This is a volunteer.

She closed the file.

The face of Emily Rose disappeared into the Manila darkness.

But the afterimage remained.

The black eyes. The broken knees.

The smile.

Erin looked at the empty Eames chair in the corner of her room.

She felt the copper taste in her mouth.

"She accepted it," Erin whispered to the empty room.

"But I don't."

She stood up. She grabbed her wine glass.

She drank.

But the wine tasted like blood.

CHAPTER 7: EMILY BEFORE

Flashback. September 1976.

The kitchen of the Rose farmhouse didn't just smell of food; it smelled of history. It smelled of yeast that had been rising in the same wooden bowl for twenty years. It smelled of cinnamon, of old coffee grounds, and of the lye soap her mother used to scrub the floorboards until they were white as bone.

Emily Rose stood at the counter, her hands buried to the wrists in dough.

She closed her eyes, letting the rhythm take her.

Push. Turn. Fold.

Push. Turn. Fold.

It was a prayer made of flour and water. It was muscle memory, ingrained in her tendons like the pattern of the seasons.

"You're going to miss this," her mother said.

Maria Rose was standing at the sink, peeling potatoes. The skin of the potatoes curled away in long, brown ribbons, falling into the metal basin with a soft *plip*.

"I can buy bread at the store, Mama," Emily said, opening her eyes. She smiled, but it felt tight. "They have a bakery near campus."

"Store bread," Maria scoffed, not looking up. "Tastes like cardboard. Tastes like nothing. You need good food if you're going to be studying all night. You need strength."

Emily looked down at the dough. It was warm, alive under her hands.

"I'll be fine, Mama. I'm nineteen."

"Nineteen is a baby," Maria said. She turned off the tap. The sudden silence in the kitchen was heavy. The only sound was the wind outside, scratching against the siding like a dog wanting to come in.

"The city is different, Emily," Maria said softly. "It's loud. It's fast. And it's... empty."

"Empty?"

"Spiritually empty. There are too many people and not enough silence for God to speak."

Emily wiped a stray strand of hair from her forehead, leaving a streak of white flour on her skin. She looked out the window.

The fields were turning gold. The corn was high, dry, rustling in the wind. The harvest was coming.

Usually, she would be here for it. She would be helping her father in the barn, the air thick with dust and diesel.

But this year, she wouldn't be here.

She was going to the University. To the city. To the world of books and coffee shops and boys who didn't smell like manure.

It felt like a liberation.

But it also felt... dangerous. Like stepping off a cliff in the dark, trusting that there was water below and not rocks.

She walked to the hallway to wash her hands.

At the end of the hall, there was a small niche in the wall. A shrine.

A statue of the Virgin Mary stood there. It was cheap plaster, painted in bright blues and whites that had faded over the years. A string of plastic rosary beads was draped over her hands. A votive candle flickered in a red glass cup.

Emily stopped.

She always stopped here. It was habit.

She knelt on the worn runner rug. Her knees popped. A sharp, dry crack.

She winced. Her knees had been aching lately. Growing pains? Or something else?

"Hail Mary, full of grace," she whispered.

She didn't pray for good grades. She didn't pray for a boyfriend.

She prayed for... protection.

Why?

She didn't know.

But lately, when the sun went down, the farmhouse didn't feel cozy. It felt sieged.

The wind sounded less like air and more like voices.

Hssssss... Em-i-ly...

She looked up at the statue.

The painted eyes of the Virgin were serene, looking down at her with infinite patience.

But then... the light from the votive candle flickered.

The shadows in the niche jumped.

For a second—just a fraction of a second—it looked like the Virgin's eyes shifted.

Looking past Emily.

Looking over her shoulder.

At the dark corner of the hallway behind her.

Emily froze.

The hair on her arms stood up. The flour on her skin felt suddenly cold, like snow.

She didn't want to turn around.

Every instinct in her body screamed *Don't look.*

But she had to.

She turned her head slowly.

The coat rack stood in the corner.

It was piled high with winter coats. Her father's heavy canvas jacket. Her mother's wool shawl.

In the dim light, the pile of clothes looked like a figure.

A tall, thin man.

Wearing a heavy coat.

And a hat. A wide-brimmed hat that shadowed his face.

He was standing perfectly still. Watching her.

"Daddy?" Emily whispered.

The figure didn't move.

"Daddy, is that you?"

Silence. Just the wind scratching at the walls.

Emily stood up. Her heart was hammering against her ribs like a trapped bird.

She took a step toward the corner.

"Who's there?"

She reached out to the light switch.

Click.

The hallway flooded with yellow light.

The figure vanished.

It was just coats. Just wool and canvas hanging on wooden pegs.

Emily let out a breath she didn't know she was holding.

"You're going crazy, Em," she whispered. "City nerves before you even get to the city."

She walked back to the kitchen.

But as she passed the shrine, she glanced at the Virgin one last time.

The statue hadn't moved.

But the votive candle...

It was out.

A thin trail of grey smoke curled up from the black wick.

There was no draft in the hall.

Emily stared at the smoke.

It smelled of wax.

And sulfur.

"Emily!" her father's voice called from the porch. "Car's loaded!"

Emily jumped.

"Coming, Daddy!"

She grabbed her bag. She didn't relight the candle.

She walked out of the house, into the bright September sun.

But the cold spot in the center of her chest didn't go away.

It felt like she had swallowed a piece of ice that wouldn't melt.

She hugged her mother on the porch. Maria felt small, fragile.

"Be good, Em," Maria whispered into her ear. "Say your prayers. Every night. Don't forget."

"I won't, Mama."

"And wear your medal. The St. Benedict medal."

"I have it on."

Emily touched the small silver chain around her neck.

Her father, Nathaniel, was waiting by the battered Ford station wagon. He looked uncomfortable in his Sunday shirt.

"Ready, princess?" he asked. His voice was gruff, hiding the fact that he was breaking inside.

"Ready," Emily lied.

She got into the car. The seat vinyl was hot from the sun.

As they drove down the long dirt driveway, dust billowing behind them like a smoke screen, Emily looked back.

The farmhouse looked small against the vast, grey sky. A wooden island in a sea of dying corn.

A crow was sitting on the fence post at the end of the drive.

It watched the car pass.

It didn't fly away.

It opened its beak and cawed.

A harsh, grating sound that sounded like metal tearing.

Emily shivered.

"Cold?" her father asked, glancing in the rearview mirror.

"Just... excited," Emily said.

But she wasn't looking at the road ahead.

She was looking at the house.

At the upstairs window. Her bedroom window.

The curtains were closed.

But she saw them move.

Just a twitch. As if someone was standing there, watching her leave.

"Goodbye," she whispered.

But the word felt wrong.

It didn't feel like she was leaving.

It felt like she was being sent.

Like a lamb being sent to market.

Or a soldier being sent to the front lines of a war she didn't even know existed.

CHAPTER 8: CAMPUS

The University was loud.

That was Emily's first impression. It was a constant, physical assault of noise. Cars honking, buses hissing, music thumping from dorm windows, construction jackhammers rattling the pavement.

It was a wall of sound that drowned out the silence of the farm.

And Emily loved it.

She loved the anonymity of it. In the noise, she couldn't hear the wind scratching at the walls. In the crowd, she couldn't feel the eyes watching her.

Her dorm room was a shoebox on the third floor of Johnson Hall. Cinderblock walls painted a pale, institutional yellow. Two beds. Two desks. One window that looked out onto a brick wall.

It was the most beautiful place she had ever seen.

It was hers.

Her roommate was a girl named Alice.

Alice was everything Emily was not. She was from Chicago. She had short, spiky hair dyed a color that didn't occur in nature—a dark, bruised plum. She wore oversized sweaters that smelled of clove cigarettes and patchouli.

"You're a virgin, right?" Alice asked within five minutes of meeting her. She was unpacking a crate of vinyl records. *The Ramones. Patti Smith. The Sex Pistols.*

Emily blushed, turning red from her neck to her hairline. She was folding her underwear into neat, square piles.

"Is it that obvious?"

Alice laughed. It was a smoky, worldly sound. "Honey, you have a crucifix on your wall, you fold your panties like origami, and you're wearing a cardigan in September. It's adorable."

Alice lit a cigarette, blowing the smoke out the open window. "Don't worry. We'll corrupt you by Thanksgiving. I'll have you drinking cheap wine and listening to punk rock in no time."

Emily laughed. It felt good to laugh.

"I like wine," she said bravely.

"Communion wine doesn't count," Alice said, winking.

The first month was a blur of joy.

Classes. Philosophy 101. Literature. Anthropology.

Emily sat in the front row. She took notes in her precise, cursive handwriting. She raised her hand. She argued about Kant and Descartes.

She walked through the quad in the autumn sunlight, kicking leaves that crunched satisfyingly under her boots.

She felt... normal.

She felt like a student. Not a farm girl. Not a "sensitive." Just a girl.

It was a Tuesday in late October when the shadow returned.

Emily was studying in the library. The "stacks"—the deep, silent rows of books in the basement.

It was late. 10:00 PM. The library was closing soon.

She was reading *The Brothers Karamazov*.

The air in the basement was cool and smelled of old paper and dust.

Scritch.

A sound from the next aisle.

Emily looked up.

"Hello?"

Silence.

Just the hum of the fluorescent lights.

Scritch. Scritch.

Like a fingernail dragging across a book spine. Or a claw testing the fabric of reality.

Emily stood up. She walked to the end of the aisle and looked down the row.

Empty.

Just rows and rows of books.

But the air...

It smelled different here.

Not paper.

It smelled wet. Like a dog that had come in from the rain. And something else.

Sulfur.

Faint, but there. The smell of a match.

"Is someone there?" she called out.

The lights flickered.

Buzz-click. Buzz-click.

For a second, the aisle went dark.

When the lights buzzed back on, Emily saw it.

At the far end of the row.

A book was on the floor.

It hadn't been there a second ago.

Emily walked toward it. Her footsteps echoed on the linoleum. *Clack. Clack.*

She knelt down.

It was a book on theology. *The Problem of Evil.*

It was open.

Face down.

As if someone had thrown it.

Emily reached out to pick it up.

The air grew cold. Freezing. Her breath puffed out in a white cloud.

She touched the book.

It was ice cold.

She snatched her hand back.

"Okay," she whispered. "Okay, that's creepy. I'm leaving."

She grabbed her bag and walked quickly to the stairs. She didn't run. She refused to run.

It's just a draft. It's just old pipes.

She burst out of the library doors and into the night.

The fog had rolled in off the lake. It was thick, white, and cold. It swallowed the streetlights, turning them into glowing, hazy orbs.

Emily wrapped her scarf tighter around her neck.

She took the shortcut through the park.

It was a path lined with old oak trees. In the day, it was beautiful. At night, in the fog, it looked like a tunnel into nowhere.

Crunch. Crunch.

Footsteps behind her.

Heavy. Deliberate.

Emily stopped.

The footsteps stopped.

She turned around.

"Alice?"

The fog swirled. Grey shapes dancing in the mist.

No answer.

Emily turned and walked faster.

Crunch. Crunch. Crunch.

The footsteps matched her pace. But they sounded... wet. *Slap. Slap.* Like bare feet on wet pavement.

Emily started to run.

The footsteps ran too.

SLAP. SLAP. SLAP.

Fast. Inhumanly fast. Closing the distance.

Emily burst out of the park and onto the lit street of the dorms.

She grabbed a lamppost, gasping for breath, her chest heaving.

She looked back at the park entrance.

The fog was a wall of white.

There was no one there.

But at the edge of the light... just where the darkness began...

She saw a shape.

A tall, thin shape.

It wasn't a student. It was too tall. Seven feet tall.

It was wearing a long coat. And a hat.

It raised a hand.

The fingers were too long. They looked like jointed twigs.

It waved.

A slow, mocking wave.

I see you, Emily.

Emily turned and ran to her dorm. She didn't stop until she was inside the lobby, under the harsh glare of the security lights.

She ran up the stairs to the third floor.

She unlocked her door and slammed it shut. She threw the deadbolt.

Alice was on her bed, reading a magazine. She looked up, startled.

"Whoa, killer," Alice said. "What's chasing you? A frat boy?"

Emily leaned against the door, sliding down until she hit the floor. She was shaking.

"Nothing," she gasped. "Just... a creep in the park."

"City life," Alice said, rolling her eyes. "Get some pepper spray. Or a whistle."

Emily nodded.

"Yeah. Pepper spray."

But she knew pepper spray wouldn't help.

She looked at the window. The fog was pressing against the glass like a face.

The thing in the park didn't have eyes.

She had seen its face in the flash of the streetlamp.

It had empty sockets filled with black fire.

And it knew where she lived.

It had followed her from the farm.

It had followed her to the library.

And now, it was outside her window.

Waiting for the lights to go out.

CHAPTER 9: FIRST NIGHT

November 1976.

The first time it fully took her, it wasn't a monster. It wasn't a voice. It was a smell.

Emily was asleep in her dorm room. It was a Friday night. Alice had gone home to Chicago for the weekend to see a boyfriend she claimed was "in a band" but was probably just unemployed.

The dorm was quiet. A rare, heavy silence that settled over the cinderblock walls like a blanket.

Emily was dreaming.

In the dream, she was back on the farm. But the corn was dead. Black stalks rattling in a wind that smelled of sulfur. The sky was the color of a bruise.

She was walking toward the barn. She didn't want to go, but her legs moved on their own. *Left. Right. Left. Right.*

The barn door was open. A mouth in the darkness.

And inside...

Something was waiting.

She woke up choking.

Her eyes snapped open.

The room was dark, lit only by the amber streetlights filtering through the cheap blinds.

She coughed, her lungs seizing.

The air in the room was thick. Oily.

"Fire," she thought. Panic flared in her chest, hot and sharp.

She sat up, throwing the covers off.

But there was no orange glow. No smoke alarm screaming. No sound of crackling wood.

Just the smell.

It was overpowering.

Burning hair. Burning rubber.

And underneath that... meat.

Seared meat.

Like a steak left on a grill until it turned to charcoal.

Emily gagged, covering her mouth with her hand.

She swung her legs out of bed.

The floor was cold. Freezing.

She walked to the window. Maybe there was a fire outside. Maybe the dumpster was burning.

She pulled the blinds up.

Nothing. Just the empty courtyard. The fog.

The smell was coming from *inside* the room.

Then the weight hit her.

It wasn't a gradual pressure. It was instant.

It felt as if the gravity in the room had suddenly increased tenfold.

CRACK.

Emily fell to her knees.

The pain was blinding. Her kneecaps slammed into the hardwood floor with the force of a hammer strike. She felt the cartilage compress, the bone grind against the wood.

She tried to stand.

She couldn't.

Her legs were locked.

Not cramped. Locked. Rigid as iron bars.

She tried to crawl.

Her arms wouldn't move. Her elbows were pinned to her sides by invisible bands of steel.

She was paralyzed.

Trapped in her own body.

"Help," she whispered.

But her voice was gone. Her throat was clamped shut. Her tongue felt swollen, heavy, like a slug in her mouth.

She stared at the floor. The grain of the wood. The dust bunnies under Alice's bed.

She could see her own breath puffing out in white clouds on the floorboards.

It's freezing.

Why was it freezing? The radiator was hissing in the corner.

She tried to lift her head.

It took every ounce of strength she had. Her neck muscles screamed.

She looked at the clock on her desk.

The red numbers burned in the dark.

3:00 AM.

The colon didn't blink.

Time had stopped.

Then, she heard it.

Creak.

The door to her closet.

She had closed it before bed. She always closed it. She hated the look of empty clothes hanging in the dark. Like shed skins.

The door was opening.

Slowly.

Inch by inch.

Eeeeeeeeee.

The hinges shrieked in the silence.

Emily watched, her heart hammering against her ribs like a fist. *Thump-thump-thump.*

The door swung wide.

It was dark inside. Darker than the room.

But something was moving in the clothes.

Shifting.

Rustling.

Like a large animal settling into a nest.

A coat fell off a hanger. *Slump.*

Then a sweater.

And then... a face appeared in the darkness.

It wasn't a face.

It was a mask of melting wax.

The features were sliding off the skull. One eye was lower than the other. The mouth was a vertical slash.

It smiled.

A wet, glistening smile that revealed too many teeth.

Emily tried to scream.

Help me. Jesus, help me.

But her mouth wouldn't open. Her jaw was locked tight.

The thing in the closet stepped out.

It was tall. Seven feet. Thin as a rail. Its skin was grey, translucent, like parchment stretched over bone.

It walked toward her.

It didn't have feet. It floated an inch above the floor.

It stopped in front of her.

It leaned down.

It smelled of the grave. Of old earth and rotting flowers.

It whispered in her ear.

"Emily..."

The voice didn't come from the thing's mouth. It came from inside her own head.

It sounded like her father. But wrong. Twisted.

"Emily... why did you leave us?"

The pressure increased. She was being crushed. Her ribs groaned. She felt a rib crack. A sharp, hot needle of pain in her side.

"You think you can hide here? In the city? With your books?"

The thing reached out a hand. Its fingers were long, tipped with black claws.

It touched her cheek.

Its skin was burning hot.

Where it touched, her skin blistered.

"You are ours," the voice whispered. *"'You have always been ours.'"

Emily closed her eyes.

She focused on the pain in her knees. The pain was real. The pain was an anchor.

Hail Mary, full of grace...

She prayed in her mind. Screaming the words silently.

...the Lord is with thee...

The thing laughed. A sound like tearing metal.

"She can't hear you. She is in Heaven. You are in the pit."

Blessed art thou among women...

The weight grew heavier. It felt like the ceiling was coming down on her.

...and blessed is the fruit of thy womb, Jesus.

At the name of Jesus, the thing shrieked.

It recoiled.

The pressure vanished.

Instantly.

Emily collapsed forward, her face hitting the floor.

She gasped, sucking in air.

The smell was gone.

The cold was gone.

She looked up.

The closet door was closed.

The room was empty.

She looked at the clock.

3:01.

The numbers blinked.

Emily lay on the floor, shivering. Her knees throbbed. Her cheek burned where the thing had touched her.

She reached up and touched her face.

Her fingers came away wet.

Blood.

And something else.

Soot.

She curled into a ball on the floor and wept.

But she didn't call for help.

Because she knew.

No one could help her.

The war had begun. And she was the battlefield.

CHAPTER 10: ERIN INVESTIGATES

The Rose farm was a grey smudge on the horizon of the flat Midwest landscape.

Erin Bruner drove her rental car down the long dirt road. The suspension groaned with every pothole.

It was raining. Of course. A relentless, cold drizzle that turned the world into a watercolor painting left out in the storm.

The fields were dead. Brown stalks of corn, broken and rotting in the mud.

Erin gripped the wheel.

She felt... exposed here.

In the city, she was insulated by glass and steel. Here, there was nothing between her and the sky. Nothing between her and the horizon.

It felt like being on the surface of the moon.

She parked in front of the farmhouse.

It was a white clapboard house, two stories, with a wraparound porch that leaned dangerously to the left. The paint was peeling in long strips, revealing the grey wood underneath.

It looked like a house that was slowly dying.

Erin got out of the car. She pulled her trench coat tight.

The wind bit at her face. It smelled of wet earth and manure.

She walked to the porch. The stairs creaked. *Groan.*

She knocked on the door.

It opened immediately.

Maria Rose stood there.

Emily's mother was a small woman, worn down by grief like a stone in a river. Her hair was grey, pulled back in a severe bun. Her hands were red, rough from work.

But her eyes were clear. Blue. Piercing.

"Ms. Bruner," she said. Her voice was soft, but it carried. "Father Moore said you would come."

The kitchen was warm. It smelled of yeast and coffee. A wood stove crackled in the corner.

"Coffee?" Maria asked.

"Please."

Erin sat at the table. It was a heavy oak table, the surface scratched and scarred by decades of meals.

She opened her briefcase. She took out a notepad.

"Mrs. Rose, I need to ask you some questions. About Emily's childhood."

Maria poured the coffee into a chipped mug. Her hand was steady.

"Emily was happy," she said, sitting down opposite Erin. "She was full of light. She loved this farm. She loved God."

"Was there any history of mental illness? In the family? Depression? Mood swings?"

Maria shook her head. "No. We are healthy people. Hardworking."

"Mrs. Rose... the medical report says Emily had Temporal Lobe Epilepsy. It causes hallucinations. Hearing voices. Seeing things."

Maria looked at Erin. Her gaze was pitying.

"You think it was a sickness."

"I think it's a medical explanation. And it's the explanation the prosecution is going to use."

"Can medicine make a girl speak in languages she never learned?" Maria asked quietly. "Can medicine make a girl know things she couldn't know?"

"What things?"

"She knew about my sin," Maria whispered. She looked down at her hands. "I had a baby. Before I met Nathaniel. I gave it up. No one knew. Not even my husband."

Erin paused. Her pen hovered over the page.

"She looked at me... with those black eyes... and she told me. She told me the name I had given the baby in my heart. *Sarah.*"

"Suggestion," Erin said, her voice professional. "Cold reading. Psychics do it all the time. They pick up on cues."

"It wasn't a trick, Ms. Bruner. It was... knowledge. Dark knowledge."

Maria stood up.

"Come with me. I want to show you something."

She put on a heavy wool shawl. She opened the back door.

"Where are we going?"

"The barn."

The walk to the barn was short, but it felt like miles. The wind pushed against them. The mud sucked at Erin's expensive boots.

The barn loomed ahead. Dark. Silent.

Maria pushed the door open.

It was cold inside. Colder than the outside.

The air was still. Stagnant.

"This is where she died," Maria said.

Erin looked around.

It was a typical barn. High rafters. Bales of hay. Tools hanging on the walls.

But in the center of the threshing floor...

A military cot.

It was stained. Dark patches on the canvas.

And on the floor...

Erin walked closer.

Scratches.

Deep gouges in the hard oak planks.

Dozens of them.

They looked like they had been made by a wild animal. A bear. Or a wolf.

Erin knelt down. She touched the wood. The splinters were sharp.

"Did an animal do this?"

"Emily did this," Maria said. Her voice echoed in the vast space. "With her fingernails."

"Why?"

"To keep from floating away."

Erin looked up. "Floating?"

"Levitating, Ms. Bruner. They lifted her up. Like a doll. She dug into the floor to hold on."

Erin touched the scratches again.

She felt it then.

The static.

The same feeling she had in her apartment at 3:00 AM.

The hair on her arms stood up.

She smelled it.

Copper.

Sulfur.

Rotting lilies.

She looked at the corner of the barn. The shadows seemed to be moving. Coalescing. Thickening into a shape.

A tall, thin shape.

"We should go," Erin said, standing up quickly. Her heart was racing.

"You feel it, don't you?" Maria asked.

"I feel the cold."

"You feel *them*," Maria said. "They are still here. They are waiting for the trial. They are waiting for *you*."

Erin walked out of the barn. Fast.

She didn't run, but it was close.

She got in her car. She locked the doors.

She started the engine.

She drove down the driveway, dust billowing behind her.

She didn't look back.

But she checked the rearview mirror.

And for a second... just a second...

She saw a face in the back seat.

Smiling.

She blinked.

It was gone.

Just the empty leather seats.

Erin gripped the wheel. Her knuckles were white.

"Psychosis," she whispered. "It's contagious. It's suggestibility."

But she knew.

She knew the smell.

She knew the feeling of eyes on her neck.

She drove faster.

Trying to outrun the sunset.

Trying to outrun the dark.